# Wintergirls

## By Laurie Halse Anderson

**(Pg 7)** . . . *When I was a real girl, with two parents and one house,* breakfast was granola topped with fresh strawberries, always eaten while reading a book propped up on the fruit bowl.

**(Pg 5)** "Why don't you have one of those muffins?" [My stepmom, Jennifer, asks.] "I bought oranges yesterday, or you could have toast or frozen waffles."

Because I can't let myself want them because I don't need a muffin (410), I don't want an orange (75) or toast (87), and waffles (180) make me gag.

**(Pg 7)** No. I can't go there. I won't think. I won't look.

I won't pollute my insides with Bluberridazzlepops or muffins or scritchscratchy shards of toast, either. Yesterday's dirt and mistakes have moved through me. I am shiny and pink inside, clean. Empty is good. Empty is strong.

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## INTRODUCTION

*The danger of habit. When you train yourself to do something over and over again, how do you break the rigorous training you've set up for yourself? In the following selection, Lia has spiraled into not eating. Counting calories, competing with her best friend to be the thinnest, Lia is caught and monitored by family, but nothing is enough to stop her from returning to old habits. What does it take to make a change? To turn toward recovery.*

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**(Pg 27)** *The first time . . .* **(Pg 9)** Mom and Dad rushed in, side by side for a change, happy that I was not dead. A nurse handed my chart to my mother. She read through it and explained the disaster to my father and then they fought, a mudslide of an argument that spewed across the antiseptic sheets and out into the hall. I was stressed/overscheduled/manic/no -- depressed/no -- in need of attention/no -- in need of discipline/in need of rest/in need/your fault/your fault/fault/fault. They branded their war on this tiny skin-bag of a girl.

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Phone calls were made. My parents force-marched me into New Seasons . . .

*They locked me up and dripped sugar water into my empty veins . . .* **(Pg 27)** *The first time they admitted me*, this body weighed 093.00 pounds.

**(Pg 28)** I was a good girl because I didn't poke holes in my skin, or write depressing poetry, and I ate and ate. They stuffed me like a pink little piggy ready for market. I bit, chewed, swallowed day after day and lied, lied, lied. (Who wants to recover? It took me years to get that tiny. I wasn't sick; I was strong.) But staying strong would keep me locked up. The only way out was to shove in food until I waddled.

Four weeks later, the gates opened. Mom drove me home and we pretended none of it ever happened, except for the meal plans and the rules and the appointments and the scales and the hurricane of my mother's disappointment.

**(Pg 46)** The doctors told Dad to buy a Blubber-O-Meter 3000, a bathroom scale with a giant dial that was easy to read. Jennifer had to do the dirty work,

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weighing me in my tattered yellow robe to make sure I stayed fat. For the first couple of months, she measured my sins every morning and called in the results to my doctor once a week. The ugly numbers made me cry.

Everyday weighing became every-other-day weighing *became every-Tuesday weighing because none of us wanted to do it in the first place . . .*

**(Pg 189)** Adrenaline kicks in when you're starving. That's what nobody understands. Except for being hungry and cold, most of the time I feel like I can do anything. It gives me superhuman powers of smell and hearing. I can see what people are thinking, stay two steps ahead of them.

**(Pg 145)** I'm hungry I need to eat.

I hate eating.

I need to eat.

I hate eating.

I need to eat.

I love not-eating.

**(Pg 161)** Why? You want to know why?

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Go to school to jump through hoops, sit up and beg, and roll over on command. Listen to the whispers that curl into your head at night, calling you ugly and fat and stupid and bitch and whore and worst of all "a disappointment." Puke and starve and cut and drink because you don't want to feel any of this. Puke and starve and cut and drink because you need an anesthetic and it works. For a while. But then the anesthetic turns into poison and by then it's too late because you are mainlining it now, straight from your soul. It is rotting you and you can't stop. Look in a mirror and find a ghost. Hear every heart-beat scream that everysinglething is wrong with you.

"Why?" is the wrong question.

Ask "Why not?"

**(Pg 46-47)** I change into the yellow robe in my bedroom and make sure the quarters I sewed into the pockets aren't making them droop. When I get to the bathroom, Jennifer is fixing her eyeliner in the mirror. I step on the scales. 107.00 fake pounds.

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**(Pg 220)** Alone . . . I strip, to weigh my faults and measure my sins . . . **(Pg 52-53)** as I step on the scale, I open my eyes. 099.00 pounds. I am officially standing on Goal Number One.

Goal Number Two is 095.00, the perfect point of balance. At 095.00, I am pure. Light enough to walk with my head up, meaty enough to fool everyone.

At 090.00, I soar. That's Goal Number Three.

**(Pg 220)** 089.00.

I could say I'm excited, but that would be a lie. The number doesn't matter. If I got down to 070.00, I'd want 065.00. If I weighed 010.00, I wouldn't be happy until I got down to 005.00. The only number that would ever be enough is 0. Zero pounds, zero life, size zero, double-zero, zero point.

***(Pg 8)*** *I [drive], windows down, music cranked, flying to the SATs.*

Did I eat breakfast? Of course not. Did I eat dinner the night before, or lunch, or anything?

The car in front of [me] brake[s] as the traffic light turn[s] yellow, then red. My edges blur. The car in

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front disappear[s]. The steering wheel, the dashboard, vanish.

**(Pg 271)** The light beyond my eyes flashflashflashes with a hundred futures for me. Doctor. Ship's captain. Forest ranger. Librarian. Beloved of that man of that woman or those children or those people who voted for me or who painted my picture. Poet. Acrobat. Engineer. Friend. Guardian. Avenging whirlwind. A million futures - not all pretty, not all long, but all of them mine.

**(Pg 8)** When I w[a]ke up, the emt-person and a cop [are] frowning. My blood pressure that of a cold snake. My heart [is] tired. My lungs [need] a nap.

**(Pg 266)** Two days later, **(Pg 274-276)** my third visit to New Seasons is the longest one yet, a marathon, not a sprint to the exit. No games this time. No midnight exercise parties in the shower for me. No dumping my food in the plants or sticking it in my underwear or bribing an attendant to lie about my intake.

The concept of eating is scary. I put all of the bites in my mouth and try not to count. It's hard. *Food is*

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*life.* I exhale, take another breath. *Food is life.* And that's the problem. When you're alive, people can hurt you. It's easier to lock everybody out. But it's a lie.

*Food is life.* I have no idea how much I weigh. This scares me to death, but I'm working on it. I am beginning to measure myself in strength, not pounds. Sometimes in smiles.

I am learning how to taste everything.

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## SOURCE INFORMATION

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## AWARD HISTORY

***NE State Qualifier***

*Cutting compliments of*
*Heather Whitney, Norfolk Public Schools, NE*

**With minor adjustments by the 4N6 Fanatics staff to ensure correlation with the original text.*